museum at Kamalapur and in museums and private collections around the world.

Though their great city was gone forever, the descendants of Rama Raya would preside over a shrinking empire for a few more decades from Penukonda, a couple of hundred kilometres to the south-east, and from other towns. Within a year of Talikota, the alliance of the sultanates fell apart, descending again into a pattern of intermittent war and peace. In the following century, they would all be absorbed into the Mughal Empire.

Two years after the war, in 1567, Caesaro Federici, an Italian traveller, wrote that 'the Citie of Vijayanagar is not altogether destroyed, yet the houses stand still, but emptie, and there is dwelling in them nothing, as is reported, but Tygres and other wild beasts.' Over two centuries later, in 1799, when Colin Mackenzie came to survey Hampi, wild animals still abounded, and 'he and his team took refuge in the Virupaksha temple . . . since it was the only place that could be securely locked at night'[43]—the place from where Vijayanagar Empire had risen nearly five centuries earlier.

A Hindu Bulwark against Islam?

Modern scholarship on Vijayanagar began with Robert Sewell's influential *A Forgotten Empire* (1900), which included the first English translations of Paes and Nuniz. He described Vijayanagar as 'a Hindu bulwark against Muhammadan conquests', whose 'fighting kings' became 'the saviors of the south for two and a half centuries'. In Sewell's lifetime, as modernity spread in the subcontinent, religious revival and sectarian feeling accompanied political awakening. In this milieu, Sewell's words roused upper-caste Hindu nationalists to romantically imagine Vijayanagar as a brave and final stand of 'traditional' Hindu religion and culture against the 'darkness' of Islam.[44] Many accepted this ideological framing, including V.S. Naipaul in *India: A Wounded Civilization* (1976). This polarizing rhetoric still dominates popular histories and perceptions, especially among contemporary Hindu nationalists.

The reality, however, was far more complex. Among scholars today, Sewell's view is largely untenable. As Wagoner writes, 'The actual pattern